



Waipapa
Taumata Rau
**University
of Auckland**

Teaching and Learning Circles

Peer-driven, reflective, and collegial professional development

Resource Pack

Teaching and Learning Circles

Teaching and Learning Circles (TLCs) bring together small groups of three to four colleagues who are curious about teaching, and who want a dedicated space to think about it together.

TLCs are designed to be **developmental, not evaluative**. As a circle member, you visit colleagues' classes and they visit yours, not to assess or advise, but to observe with curiosity and reflect on what you see. The focus is always on your own practice: what watching someone else teach makes you notice, question, and want to try.

Great teaching rarely develops in isolation, and TLCs create exactly that opportunity: a structured, collegial space to step into a colleague's classroom, see something new, and bring it back to your own practice.

Benefits

Taking part in a TLC offers you the chance to:

- Discover new teaching approaches by seeing colleagues in action across disciplines
- Build connections with educators beyond your immediate teaching team
- Deepen your understanding of how students experience learning
- Gain confidence in your own practice through collegial affirmation
- Set aside dedicated time for reflection in a busy semester
- Generate evidence of professional engagement that can support your career goals

Time commitment: approximately **5–6 hours** across the semester: around 2–3 hours of class visits and 2–3 hours of reflection and group meetings.

TLCs and *TeachWell@UoA* Framework

TLCs align directly with the **Reflect** and **Contribute** domains of the *TeachWell@UoA* Framework, and through the observation lenses you choose, your circle also touches on **Teach**, **Design**, and **Assess**.

Any reflections or insights you generate through the TLC process are yours to use however you find meaningful — in your ADPR, your Academic Career Portfolio, or simply in your own teaching.

Learning Across Disciplines

TLCs work well with members from different disciplines, and this is by design. When you observe teaching in a field you do not know, you stop tracking the content and start noticing the teaching itself: how the teacher opens the session, asks questions, responds to students, and structures time.

Research on cross-disciplinary peer observation finds that observers from outside a field focus more naturally on pedagogy and adopt the student perspective more easily.¹ The difference in discipline creates a sense of safety and comfort in authentically engaging in dialogue about practice, because neither party is the content expert and both are genuinely learning.

That said, circles formed within a discipline or teaching team are equally valid. Whatever the context, you will always find something worth reflecting on.

Four Cornerstones

TLCs draw on an established tradition of peer observation practice developed across universities internationally. At the heart of every successful programme are four shared commitments that make collegial observation feel safe, worthwhile, and generative.

Reciprocity

Every member both observes and is observed. There are no experts and no novices, only peers, each taking turns to open their classroom and to sit in someone else's. This shared trust is what makes the circle work.

Appreciation

TLC observations are oriented toward noticing and celebrating what works, in your colleagues' classrooms and in your own. The mindset is one of curiosity and generosity, not critique or correction.

Self-referential reflection

The focus is always on what *you* take away, not on evaluating the person you observed. Every insight is framed around your own teaching: *"This made me think about..."* rather than *"They should have..."*

Mutual respect

Members enter each other's classrooms with genuine empathy for the teacher, the students, and the context. Different disciplines, class sizes, and teaching situations call for different approaches, and respect means recognising that.

¹O'Keeffe M. et al. (2021). *International Journal for Academic Development*.

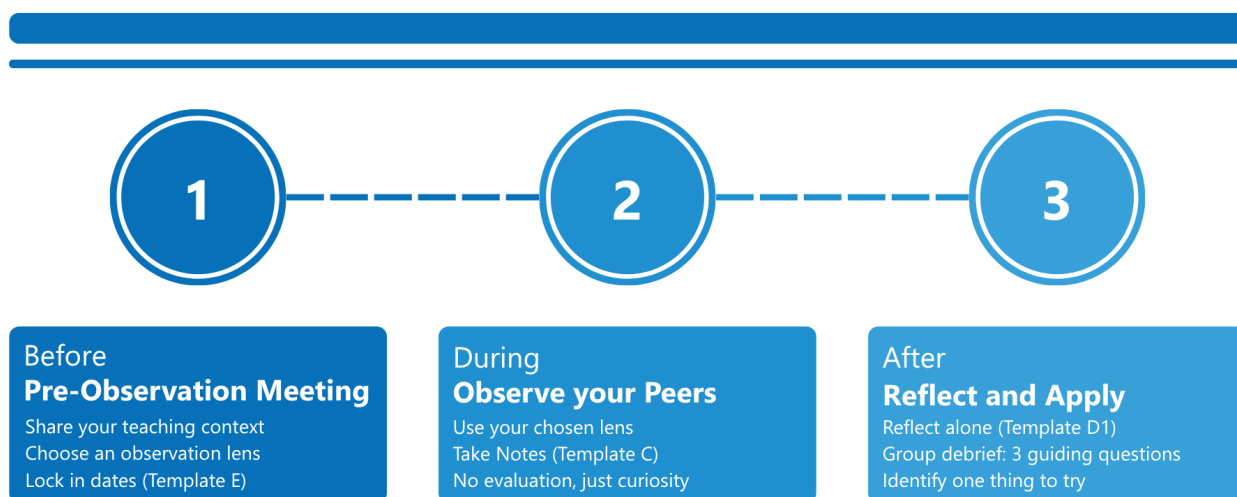
Your Circle, Your Choice

The framework gives you structure and resources, but how your circle uses them is something you decide together. Some circles focus purely on observation and self-reflection. Some add informal conversation after visits. Some use the circle mainly as a space for regular dialogue about teaching.

All of these approaches are valid, and your first meeting is the place to agree on what suits your group best.

The TLC Process

Your TLC moves through three stages. The sections that follow walk you through each one in turn.



Pre-Observation

Stage 1

Once your circle has been formed, your first step is to connect as a group. This can happen however works best: a brief catch-up, a Teams call, or a message thread. The aim is to share your teaching contexts and sort out schedules before observations begin.

What to organise

- Each member completes **Template A** (Pre-Observation Reflection) privately and shares context about their class with the group (or as much or as little as they choose with the group).
- Each observer selects one or two lenses that resonate with their own teaching questions (see next page).
- Lock in all observation dates together using **Template E** (Circle Scheduling).

Tip: Locking in dates early is the single most effective thing your circle can do. Aim to complete all observations within six weeks of your circle forming, before schedules fill up.

A lens gives your observation a starting point. It guides where your attention begins, without limiting what you notice. Before each visit, choose one or two lenses that connect with your own teaching questions. **Template B** (Observation Lenses at a Glance) is a quick reference to bring to every visit. Lenses are aligned to the domains of the TeachWell@UoA Framework.

Lens 1: Student engagement and learning

TeachWell: Teach

- How students respond to questions, tasks, or transitions
- What draws students in or loses their attention
- Whether engagement appears equitable across the class

Lens 2: Course design in action

TeachWell: Design

- How the session's structure and sequencing supports learning
- Whether activities connect clearly to outcomes
- What you might borrow or adapt for your own course

Lens 3: Inclusive and responsive teaching

TeachWell: Teach / Te Tiriti

- How the teacher acknowledges and works with student diversity
- Whether the learning environment feels welcoming to all
- Moments of manaakitanga (hospitality, kindness, and generosity) visible in practice

Lens 4: Feedback and assessment in practice

TeachWell: Assess

- How the teacher provides in-session feedback
- The teacher's responses when students appear uncertain
- What assessment thinking is embedded beyond formal tasks

Lens 5: Teaching as professional reflection

TeachWell: Reflect

- Which teaching decisions are most visible, and what might they reveal?
- What assumptions about learning underpin the session?
- Does anything here challenge or confirm your own teaching approach?

For the host: there is no need to prepare anything special. Teach as you normally would.

For observers: TLC observations are not peer review. The aim is reflection, not critique. Keep your attention on what you notice and what it prompts you to think about in your own teaching.

Do

- Observe as a learner, not an evaluator
- Use your chosen lens as a starting point
- Sit with students where possible
- Use **Template C** (Observation Notes) if helpful; brief mental notes are equally fine
- Frame insights around your own teaching: *"This made me think about..."*
- Maintain confidentiality within the circle

Don't

- Judge or evaluate teaching performance
- Offer unsolicited feedback during or immediately after the class
- Focus on what you would have done differently
- Share observations outside the circle without explicit agreement from all members

Once all observations are complete, the circle meets to share what each member noticed and what it prompted them to think about for their own teaching. The conversation is structured in three parts. Complete **Template D1** privately beforehand and use **Template D2** to guide the discussion.

1 What?
Descriptive observations from your visits. Factual and specific, no evaluation.
"I noticed that..." "I was struck by..."

2 So What?
What did those observations prompt you to think about in relation to your own teaching?
"This made me reflect on my own practice because..."

3 Now What?
What is each member considering trying or changing as a result of the TLC experience?
"One thing I want to try is..." "A question I want to keep exploring is..."

Pre-Observation Reflection

A

Complete privately before your circle first connects

Share as much or as little as you choose — this is a conversation starter, not an evaluation

Name

Paper / class being offered for observation

1

What are your main goals for students in this paper?

What do you most want students to understand, be able to do, or experience by the end?

2

What are you currently experimenting with or working on in your teaching?

This could be something new you are trying, a challenge you are navigating, or an area you are curious about.

3

What feels settled and confident in your teaching right now? What feels less so?

Honest answers here help your circle understand where you are, not where you think you should be.

4

What would you like your observers to pay attention to when they visit?

This is optional — observers follow their own lens. But if there is something specific you are curious about, share it.

5

What, if anything, makes you feel apprehensive about being observed?

Named anxieties tend to shrink. This stays within your circle.

6

What are you hoping to take away from this TLC?

Observation Lenses

B

Choose one or two lenses before each visit — bring this page with you
The lens guides where your attention starts. Anything outside it that catches your eye is equally worth noting.

Lenses are chosen by the **observer**, not the host. The question to ask yourself before each visit is: *what aspect of teaching am I most curious about right now in my own practice?* Let that guide your choice.

1 Student engagement and learning

TeachWell: Teach

- ▷ How students respond to questions, tasks, and transitions
- ▷ What draws students in or loses their attention
- ▷ Whether participation feels equitable across the class

2 Course design in action

TeachWell: Design

- ▷ How the session's structure and sequencing supports learning
- ▷ Whether activities connect clearly to learning outcomes
- ▷ What you might borrow or adapt for your own course design

3 Inclusive and responsive teaching

TeachWell: Teach / Te Tiriti

- ▷ How the teacher acknowledges and works with student diversity
- ▷ Whether the environment feels welcoming and safe for all
- ▷ Moments of manaakitanga (hospitability, kindness, and generosity) visible in practice

4 Feedback and assessment in practice

TeachWell: Assess

- ▷ How the teacher checks and responds to student understanding
- ▷ How misunderstandings or uncertainty are noticed and addressed
- ▷ What assessment thinking is embedded beyond formal tasks

5 Teaching as professional reflection

TeachWell: Reflect

- ▷ Which teaching decisions are most visible, and what might they reveal?
- ▷ What assumptions about learning appear to underpin the session?
- ▷ Does anything here challenge or confirm your own teaching approach?

Before each visit, ask yourself: *"What aspect of my own teaching am I most curious about right now?" Let that be your lens.*



Observation Notes

Print and bring to each visit — these notes are yours and stay within your circle
Use your chosen lens as a starting point. Note anything that catches your eye.

Observer

Host

Date

My lens

Paper / class

Class format *lecture / tutorial / lab / online / other*

Category

What I notice

Descriptive: what is happening

What this makes me think about

Connections to your own teaching, questions it raises, reflections

Introduction

How does the teacher open the session? What are students doing as class begins?

Voice & presence

Tone, energy, pace of speech. Where does the teacher stand or move?

Questions & dialogue

What kinds of questions are asked? How long is the wait time? Do students ask questions too?

Student engagement

What are students doing — listening, discussing, on laptops? How does the teacher read the room?

Technology & resources

What tools or materials are used, and how do they support learning?

Inclusive practice

Who is participating? Does the environment feel welcoming to everyone?

Pacing & structure

Does the session feel rushed or spacious? Is the structure visible to students?

Conclusion

How does the class end? Is there a wrap-up, and does it feel complete?

Something I want to try in my own teaching

What surprised me most

Reflect and Apply: Individual

D1

Complete privately before your group debrief — bring it along

Focus on what you noticed and what it means for your own teaching. These reflections are yours.

1 What stood out most across your observations?

Think about patterns or moments that surprised you, stayed with you, or challenged an assumption you held about teaching.

2 What is one thing you noticed in a colleague's class that you want to try or adapt?

Be specific: what was it, and how might it work in your own context?

3 Being back in the role of learner — what did it feel like? What does that prompt you to think about?

Consider the student experience in your own classes: what might they notice, feel, or need that you hadn't fully considered?

4 What do you now see differently about your own teaching?

This might be a strength you recognised, an assumption that was challenged, or something you want to change.

One concrete thing I am taking into my teaching next semester:

Reflect and Apply: Group

D2 Use this to structure your group debrief — after everyone has completed D1
This is not a feedback session on colleagues' teaching. The focus is always on what each member learned for their own practice.

Date

Location

Present

1

What? Share descriptive observations from your visits. Factual and specific, no evaluation.

"I noticed..." "I was struck by..." "Something that caught my attention was..."

Notes:

2

So What? What did those observations prompt you to think about in relation to your own teaching?

"This made me reflect on my own practice because..." "It raised a question for me about..."

Notes:

3

Now What? What is each member considering trying or changing? What question do you want to keep exploring?

"One thing I want to try is..." "A question I want to keep exploring is..."

Notes:

E

Circle Scheduling

Complete when your circle first connects. Lock in all dates in one go.

Each member records the class they are offering for observation and any context observers should know.

Member 1

Name	Email / contact		
Course / paper	Date	Time	Location
Context for observers			

Member 2

Name	Email / contact		
Course / paper	Date	Time	Location
Context for observers			

Member 3

Name	Email / contact		
Course / paper	Date	Time	Location
Context for observers			

Member 4

Name	Email / contact		
Course / paper	Date	Time	Location
Context for observers			

References

The design of this resource pack is grounded in international research on peer observation and reflective practice, in established Teaching Squares programme guides, and in the *TeachWell@UoA* Framework. The sources below informed the principles, the observation lenses, and the developmental, non-evaluative approach that shape every section.

Teaching Squares programme guides

- Berenson, C. (2017). *Teaching Squares: Observe and reflect on teaching and learning*. Taylor Institute for Teaching and Learning, University of Calgary.
- Colorado State University. (2024). *Teaching Squares peer observation program facilitation guide*. The Institute for Learning and Teaching (TILT), Colorado State University.
- University of Otago & Victoria University of Wellington. (n.d.). *Teaching and Learning Circles* [Resource pack]. Developed by the University of Otago (Division of Humanities and Higher Education Development Centre) and adapted by the Victoria University of Wellington Centre for Academic Development for Ako Aotearoa.

Peer-reviewed research and reviews

- Corcelles-Seuba, M., Sala-Bars, I., Soler, M., & Duran, D. (2024). Impact of reciprocal peer observation on teacher collaboration perceptions. *British Educational Research Journal*, 50(3), 981–1001. <https://doi.org/10.1002/berj.3958>
- Cutroni, L., & Paladino, A. (2023). Peer-ing in: A systematic review and framework of peer review of teaching in higher education. *Teaching and Teacher Education*, 133, 104302. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tate.2023.104302>
- Esterhazy, R., de Lange, T., Bastiansen, S., & Wittek, A. L. (2021). Moving beyond peer review of teaching: A conceptual framework for collegial faculty development. *Review of Educational Research*, 91(2), 237–271. <https://doi.org/10.3102/0034654321990721>
- Kanuka, H., & Sadowski, C. (2020). Reflective peer observations of university teaching: A Canadian case study. *Journal of University Teaching and Learning Practice*, 17(5), Article 11.
- Miquel, E., Monguillot, M., Soler, M., & Duran, D. (2024). Reciprocal peer observation: A mechanism to identify professional learning goals. *Education Inquiry*. <https://doi.org/10.1080/20004508.2024.2370116>
- O’Keeffe, M., Crehan, M., Munro, M., Logan, A., Farrell, A. M., Clarke, E., Flood, M., Ward, M., Andreeva, T., Van Egeraat, C., Heaney, F., Curran, D., & Clinton, E. (2021). Exploring the role of peer observation of teaching in facilitating cross-institutional professional conversations about teaching and learning. *International Journal for Academic Development*, 26(3), 266–278. <https://doi.org/10.1080/1360144X.2021.1954524>
- O’Riordan, F., Buckley, K., & Lincoln, A. (2021). *Peer observation of teaching: Can POT enhance professional development practices within higher education? A literature scoping review*. Zenodo. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.4494444>

Frameworks and institutional sources

- Rogers, T., Wass, R., Timmermans, J., & Golding, C. (2019). *A framework for enhancing teaching culture and practice*. Ako Aotearoa — The National Centre for Tertiary Teaching Excellence.
- University of Auckland. (2024). *TeachWell@UoA Framework*. Waipapa Taumata Rau, University of Auckland.

Contact and Support

Teaching and Learning Circles are designed to be flexible and genuinely supportive. If you have questions at any stage of the semester, we are here to help.

General Enquiries

For questions about the TLC programme, group formation, scheduling, or resources, please contact:

TLC Team

Email:

teachinglearningcircles@auckland.ac.nz

Templates and Resources

The templates in this pack are also available digitally via the TLC website or shared workspace:

TLC Resources

zachsaunders88.github.io/tlc-uoa

Support During the Semester

You are encouraged to get in touch if you:

- Need help with timetabling or rescheduling observations
- Have questions about observation protocols or reflection tools
- Are unsure how to approach a conversation or debrief
- Have any concerns about participation or group dynamics

The sooner you get in touch, the better. Most questions are common ones we can resolve quickly.

Confidentiality and Care

All Teaching and Learning Circle activities are developmental and non-evaluative. Any concerns raised will be handled respectfully and, where appropriate, confidentially. Support is offered to ensure the experience remains constructive and positive for all participants.

End-of-Semester Feedback

At the end of each semester, we will invite you to share brief, anonymous feedback to help the programme grow. There is no obligation to respond, and responses are never linked to individual participants or circles.

Teaching contexts at Waipapa Taumata Rau vary widely, and participation may look different across disciplines, modes, and career stages. Please reach out if you need support: flexibility is built into the TLC model.